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Sociology 101

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Sociological Portfolio

Self-reflection components:

1. Select one exam question from Exam 1 copy and paste your response to the selected exam question above your self-reflection about each selected question.

From the 8 Basic Needs list, "promote social unity", how does conflict increase in a society if this basic need is not present? State one specific example to explain how the social structure of a society would be impacted by such conflict. (2) Arguably the need most dire in my society, many institutions, statuses, and roles exist to promote social unity. It seems simple, but when we stand divided as a society, and we have limited power and resources within that society, Marx has taught us that conflict rises and threatens the delicate balance of the social structure. When social unity is maintained, however, it is seen as an issue of "do we have enough resources?" instead of "do I have enough resources?".

a) Specifically explain why you included this exam question in your portfolio? (2.5)

I included this exam question because I view it as highly topical, because it is often underexamined, and because I believe that I summarized it eloquently in the final statement of my response.

b) How did the question and your response enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

I claim that this social need is often neglected by my society, and I am no different. I often neglect to consider aspects seemingly this apparent, and that is a failure of critical thinking and sociological awareness on my part. This question forced me to consider it more closely, and

allowed me to formalize ideas which had only floated around the back of my consciousness previously.

2. Select one exam question from Exam 2 copy and paste your response to the selected exam question above your self-reflection about each selected question.

5A. Describe a specific example of sexism that you have experienced or witnessed. (1) As someone who doesn't conform to my society's yexpectations of sex and gender, and as someone who is often perceived more feminine than masculine by members of my highly patriarchal society, I have observed and experienced countless examples of sexism in my life, but the most interesting to me is a phenomenon arising specifically from my gender nonconformity. People are generally able to correctly identify me as transgender, but almost everyone assumes either that I am transmasculine or that I am transfeminine, and very few ever correctly identify me as nonbinary.

This leads most well-intentioned individuals to accidentally misgender me as either masculine or feminine, but it also allows me to see the difference in treatment from those who are not well-intentioned. When I am attacked for my nonconformity by those who believe me to transfeminine, I am treated as an infiltrator, an attacker, an inherently strong and violent exploiter of weak and vulnerable women. When these bad actors misidentify me as transmasculine however, I am treated as a weak-minded victim, manipulated and overpowered by evil predators without the protection of the "good men" who can save my mind and body.

To both of these types of individuals, I am exactly the same person, I present myself exactly the same, and I defy their gendered expectations in exactly the same ways, however this one distinction–this presumption of my sex–determines if I align with the sexist narrative of inherent male superiority and represent the idea that someone offered this supposedly superior maleness would choose something else over it or the sexist narrative of the tragic delusions that a female individual could ever be equal to a male one, especially in sex or gender itself.

a) Specifically explain why you included this exam question in your portfolio? (2.5)

I included this question because I believe that I have a unique perspective on it which effectively characterizes the concept of sexism and its manifestations in my society.

b) How did the question and your response enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

My perspective in this area was already quite rich, however, as with much of this class, it enriched my sociological understanding by linking this perspective explicitly with sociology and examining it explicitly through that lens.

3. Select an in-class group processing activity (write a 2-3 sentence description)

In one of our class sessions, we ventured outside to participate in an identity circle. I listed various pre-selected identity groups to my professor and colleagues, and we all stepped into the circle of we felt that we identified with that group. Once we had worked our way through each identity my professor had selected, we returned to the classroom to discuss what we had discovered about ourselves, our colleagues, and the sociological concept of identity.

a) Specifically explain why you included this activity in your portfolio? (2.5)

While I have participated in this activity many times, I have not led it before, and the results are different each time depending on the group. In this way, it is an activity which never loses meaning or purpose, and which always has more to teach.

b) How did the activity enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

Due to the activity's nature of reflecting different learnings depending on the composition of the group participating in it, it enriches my sociological understanding of identity in some way each time.

4. Select a second in-class group processing activity (write a 2-3 sentence description)

One of our first in-class group activities was an exploration of the three primary sociological theories, functionalism, symbolic interactionism, and conflict theory. Participating in this activity, we each identified which of the primary sociological theories was most applicable in various contexts and defended our claims.

a) Specifically explain why you included this activity in your portfolio? (2.5)

I selected this activity because it served as an important introduction to the foundational theories of the discipline of sociology.

b) How did the activity enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

This activity revealed the interconnection between each of these theories and the ways in which any given issue or concept can be analyzed through the lens of any of them, while also teaching us to select the most effective theory for any situation.

5. Select a third in-class group processing activity (write a 2-3 sentence description)

The first in-class activity I participated in as part of this course was a sociological categorization of my college as associational or communal (Gesselschafft or Gemeinschafft). We walked the campus, noting observations to support one classification or the other, and then regrouped to discuss our findings.

a) Specifically explain why you included this activity in your portfolio? (2.5)

The vast majority of our other in-class activities followed one of two identical formats, but this activity was entirely unique.

b) How did the activity enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

This activity provided an effective introduction to the real-world practice of the discipline of sociology, beyond the theoretical nature of most of the course.

6. Select a homework assignment and copy and paste your response to the selected assignment above your self-reflection about the selected assignment.

If you were omnipotent, what specifically would you change in US society's Marriage & Family social institution? (2) Our current conceptualization of the structures of marriage and family in the US are predicated on the question of "who should be permitted to participate?" and thus are so fundamentally flawed that reforming specific aspects of it is a doomed endeavor. Fortunately, this hypothetical assumes my omnipotence, which means I can simply replace these entire institutions with a system that actually fulfill their purpose: to foster and recognize the human phenomenon of love in two of its many forms. This system would be simple: any individuals mutually interested in marriage are married, any individuals mutually identifying as family are family, and any individual not interested in spousal or familial ties with any other individual does not have those ties. This would remove barriers to equality for same-sex couples, polyamorous individuals, those with disabilities, children of abusive households, interracial families, and other groups, many of which currently do not have equality of marriage or in their family life even under a purportedly more "progressive" state such as the US.

If you were omnipotent, what specifically would you change in US society's Education social institution? (2) As with our institutions of marriage and family, I believe that specific reform to an "education" system concerned with monitoring the future productive capacity of children and devaluing the humanity of those with smaller numbers in a spreadsheet is a fundamentally flawed endeavor. Instead, I would discard the system entirely and embrace the reality of education: that it is not formal instruction of a child by a teacher in a specific discipline but rather any individual's acquisition of knowledge or change of beliefs as a result of new information. This includes the independent practice of curiosity, the formal structure of the scientific method, and even simply the moments in our life that stick with us and impact who we are. It even includes a parent's approach to raising their child, though we tend to refer to this as "parenting" instead in an attempt to distance it with pedagogy and protect our shared delusion that there is some natural or inherent logic to our view of the parent as supreme arbiter of their child's life.

In this perfect system, anyone with a desire to know or understand anything would have the resources to do so. We wouldn't attempt to quantify "success" through arbitrary (and often overtly bigoted) performance metrics, but would instead recognize this pursuit of knowledge as "success" in and of itself. We as students would be slaves not to grade books and bureaucracy but to our own penchants for discovery. The best part is that after all current US residents have died, the metaphorical "US of Theseus" which would be left behind would consist entirely of individuals whose natural "childhood curiosity" had never been stamped out by our hyper-rationalized drive for productivity.

If you were omnipotent, what specifically would you change in US society's Political and Governance social institution? (2) As with marriage, family, and educational institutions, I would remove our current economic system entirely rather than attempt to reform it. Unlike with those institutions, however, I would not shape anything to replace it. I believe that the concept of a "state" or "government," predicated upon the laughable delusion that a collective of humans has more to gain from willingly accepting obedience to an individual or small group than by simply organizing and seizing it themselves. I reject the ridiculous notion that our natural state is violence and mutual destruction and that penal codes, militarized police forces, or religious codes are required to (or even effective at) regulating this nature. Instead, I recognize these things as symptoms of greater individual and systemic issues, and I know that an efficient, formalized system of regulations cannot address such issues.

Instead I would allow things to be resolved naturally. If an individual in a community routinely acts against the interests of the community, it is the job of the community members actually affected by and aware of the complexities of the situation to resolve the issue as they see fit. It can be uncomfortable to consider the possibility under such absence of any system of governance whatsoever that the community may judge the situation "wrong," but I see this not as a fault in the system but as its core feature. Not every situation should be judged as I (or any other individual or small group) would judge it, and no situation should be judged based on generalized systems of regulation.

If you were omnipotent, what specifically would you change in US society's Economic social institution? (2) As with government, I would simply tear down the entire system and allow nothing to replace it. We are told that formal structures of private ownership and the hierarchical cruelty of capitalism arise naturally, but examining the reality of propaganda machines, the modern panopticon of digital surveillance, and the militarized, masked, armed police force disappearing people to foreign concentration camps *for profit*, it becomes pretty clear that none of these things would be necessary to enforce a natural order.

The true natural order of things is for people to produce what they can, and want to produce and for them to share the surplus of this production with those they wish to reciprocate the gesture. We naturally respect each other to receive respect, collaborate to benefit from collaboration, and organize to exponentially increase ability. We are a species of social animals, and we only accept hierarchical ideas of personal benefit to other's detriment when we are forced into a real or perceived state of extreme scarcity. The carefully maintained illusion of such scarcity in the US as vacant homes and unimaginable hoards of food rot, combined with the hope that if the ruling class *became* the ruling class, any individual could as well is the only thing that keeps us content to battle for scraps while one billionaire can control more wealth than entire *occupations*.

If you were omnipotent, what specifically would you change in US society's Health care social institution? (2) Unlike with any other institution highlighted in this exercise, our healthcare system is actually close enough to functional that it could be perfected through reform. As ludicrous as it sounds given the material impact of our current system, I even believe it would in fact only require a single specific change to be perfect. I would simply allow every individual interested in improving the overall health of their community as well as the health of any individual within it to participate in the healthcare system, and root all other individuals out of it at every level. The issues with our current system come from "educators" and desk jockeys regulated as strongly as L'Croix is flavored and a body of practioners bound by a revered pinky swear to do no harm and selectively punished in retrospect for irreparable harm to human life. As such, this omnipotent verification of intention would be more than sufficient to animate our

significant medical resources into an efficient machine of compassion and healing rather than of exploitation and negligence.

a) Specifically explain why you included this assignment in your portfolio? (2.5)

I included this assignment because I have never been assigned anything like it before, and because I believe that my theoretical use of omnipotence likely differs significantly from most others'.

b) How did the assignment enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

This assignment forced me to seriously consider my true, unadulterated ideals rather than filtering them through the context of my own society and what change would be attainable for me within it, and I had never done that before.

7. Select a second homework assignment and copy and paste your response to the selected assignment above your self-reflection about the selected assignment.

1. From the lists of words and phrases below, list six words that you **most** associate with the concept of SLAVERY. (3)

lack of freedom, forced labor, exploitation, work, power, and money

2. Briefly explain your reasoning for selecting each of your 6 words. (3)

Slavery concerns the ownership of one person over another, which inherently infringes upon the freedoms of the party reduced in whole or part to property. Further, while not all forms of forced labor constitute slavery, slavery almost always involves, if not exists for the purpose of, compelled labor. Given the financial benefit this offers the owning party, the practice is

inherently exploitative in all of its forms. This same relationship also inseparably ties it to work, power, and money.

3. Access the "What We Do" tab on this website. Select "Where We Work" and identify 1 project, note the title, and define and describe the form(s)* of slavery discussed in the project. (2)

The Anti-Trafficking Monitoring group's Recovery Needs Assessment was a project undertaken by the Anti-Slavery International-funded ATMG to monitor adherence of the UK government to its laws against specifically human trafficking. This practice, while legally distinct from slavery, involves the procurement and transportation of people against their wishes for profit, and is thus inextricably linked to and instrumental in the operation of slavery historically and today.

4. Visit the “Reports & Resources” section of the Anti-Slavery web site. Select "Resources". Peruse one of these areas that you find particularly interesting and specifically explain how you gained new insight into the topic of social inequalities. (2)

I explored a paper on the relationship between compulsory and/or exploitative labor practices and business pioneering the "platform economy" of services offered primarily or exclusively through digital platforms. I had been previously of many specific examples of this (ride share services such as Uber, fast fashion platforms like SHEIN, "freelancing" sites such as Upwork, etc), but I had not yet considered the structural and systemic exploitation inherent to the concept. I hope this report reaches enough workers globally that no one will ever fail to consider that again.

5. Examine the Universal Declaration of Human Rights Which four primary Articles, from the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, deal with issues of slavery? Why did you select these above any of the others? (5)

Article 1, by establishing the fundamental principle of human rights, is by nature inherently related to any violation of those rights. Article 2 is similarly relevant, but applies more specific and legally explicit terms to support the idea of human rights. Article 4 directly bars the practice

of slavery as defined by international law. Article 23, most crucially, bars many specific practices associated with and/or fundamental to slavery, guaranteeing the right to free labor for all.

6. After reading Ashique's story, a microsociological example, how has your understanding of modern slavey expanded to a macrosociological level? Explain your reasoning. (2)

I have held both a microsociological and macrosociological understanding of modern slavery for quite some time, but compared to Ashique's individual anecdote of modern slavery, the Anti-Slavery International reports and necessity of explicit regulation even internationally (not that international regulation is particularly effective) paint a systemic picture in which Ashique's voice is just one of many screams in a well-oiled machine of malice for profit.

7. Examine your list of words again from questions #1 & #2, would you select the same words again? Why/Why not? (2)

I would select the same words for the same meanings. Slavery is so thoroughly ubiquitous globally today that practically any concept could be connected to it, but the terms I initially selected are the most emblematic of the specific practice of slavery as defined in international law.

8. After viewing the pyramid graphic **and** completing this assignment, which sociology theory [conflict, structural functionalism, or symbolic interactionism] best explains the social construct of race? Why do you think so? (2)

Any of these theories could by used to analyze the concept of race and its role in human societies, as with any other sociological phenomenon, but I believe that conflict theory would be the most insightful. Since the very beginning, race has been defined by those classifying themselves as white Europeans to describe perceived deviation of others from themselves.

They have also always been defined hierarchically in a way that imposes ideas of superiority and thus inherently prescribes a preference in the way power is exerted by certain groups over others in a world of real or artificial scarcity. This expression of conflict theory, similarly to the

patriarchy, is especially devious due to its uncanny ability to masquerade as science and be accepted by its perpetrators and victims alike as "natural."

a) Specifically explain why you included this assignment in your portfolio? (2.5)

This assignment touches on a frequently overlooked issue in many modern societies (including my own) and which I am incredibly passionate about.

b) How did the assignment enrich your sociological perspective? (2.5)

While I have extensively researched this issue on my own, and had in fact just given a presentation about it the week prior, this assignment included access to a resource I had not perused before, which in turn led me to a newfound understanding of a specific subissue of modern slavery in question 4.

8. Consider all components of this sociology course:

a) How has this course challenged/changed your previous knowledge and perceptions and enriched your sociological perspective? (2.5)

My knowledge and perceptions coming into this course are largely still my knowledge and perceptions today, however this course gave me the tools to express my existing ideas, knowledge, and perspectives formally in a sociological context.

b) How have you already used/shared your enriched sociological perspective? (2.5)

As this course mostly contextualized my existing knowledge and beliefs through the lens of sociology, anywhere this knowledge and these beliefs were previously applied, they are now applied within a sociological framework.

c) How will you use this enriched sociological perspective in your future academics, career, and personal life? (2.5)

As a member of a human society, sociology impacts me every moment of my life. Now that I have the framework necessary to conceptualize these impacts sociologically, I will continue to do so in all contexts for the rest of my life.

d) How has this course met your expectations? (2.5)

This course far exceeded my expectation of a 101-level general education course by consistently providing me with new information and, at all points at which it failed in that, consistently recontextualized my existing information in interesting ways. The vast majority of my experiences with these courses involve almost no change in my knowledge or understanding whatsoever, so that was my expectation.

e) What recommendations do you have for improving the content, teaching, and/or assessment of the course? (2.5)

The content of the course was incredibly interesting, and the assessment of our learning throughout it allowed immense freedom of expression while applying relatively insignificant stress, but much of the in-class activities became repetitive after a while. The learnings themselves were not boring, but I can only be stimulated by so many gallery walks and four-corners style activities before the formats lose their powers of engagement.